

erate bargain because it had been on the market a while and sat a couple of doors down from a foreclosed home owned by a bank. But when our first pick for a real estate agent included our house in her sales comps (for a market analysis, not an appraisal), she saw a downward market trend and panicked. We quickly found a more enthusiastic and clear-thinking agent, who helped us to sell the home at a reasonable price within 30 days. Housing prices can rise and fall, but one transaction doesn't make a trend.

These tips should give you a good indication of your home's value until you are ready to get a certified appraisal. — **Julie Rains**

How to Find Savings in Every Room

I once walked through the entire house with a pencil and paper, finding, quite literally, savings in every room. Where I've found most of the savings opportunities are in the areas of consumable products and hard infrastructure. Here's a break-



down of where I found the savings opportunities, room by room.

THE BEDROOM

Overstock Sheets

Since we have relocated to the land of reasonable shopping opportunities, this was a bit easier to do. With access to Ross, Marshalls, and other discount overstock stores, we found great high-quality sheets that usually go for over \$100 for under \$40. Having three sets of sheets per bed is more than enough. It allows you to have one set in the laundry, one on the bed, and one clean backup set for an unexpected need.

Universal Bed Frames

They don't get much cheaper than this. We got one delivered with the mattress set for under \$50. What I love about these things is that they collapse down to a very transportable size for moving, and they save you the